

PUCD 2035

Core 1: Interaction Lab

Last Updated: 04 September, 2026

Program	School of Art, Media, and Technology: Communication Design
CRN	2751
Semester	Fall 2026
Meeting Day	Tuesday
Meeting Time	9:00am - 11:40am
Building/Room/ Zoom	66 5th Ave 824
Instructor & Email	Severin Bunse severinbunse@gmail.com
Class Website	https://severinbunse.github.io/Core1_2026/

Course Description

Core 1 Interaction Lab is designed to introduce students to programming as a creative medium—as a way of making and exploring. The coursework focuses on developing a vocabulary of interaction design principles which can then be applied across a range of platforms. Students are encouraged to experiment with various media, tools, and techniques, ultimately producing a portfolio of interactive and visual projects designed for the screen. An emphasis is placed on typography as it applies to a screen context, research-based problem solving and a learning-through-making approach to technical skill building. Historical and current interaction design precedents will be discussed.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the semester, students will be able to:

1. Use a basic vocabulary of interactive media to both give and respond to critique productively.
2. Create compelling interactive experiences through more careful and inspired interpretation/translation of content (i.e. develop great design concepts).
3. Demonstrate an understanding of the iterative making process in interaction design, using incremental methods such as prototyping, user research and evaluation to build toward more advanced work.
4. Conceptualize a product, object, or experience for the web and realize it through coding.
5. Evaluate the difference in designing interfaces for different kinds of devices, their limitations and specific user situations including responsive websites and apps for mobile.

6. Evaluate how typography and its variables are applied to interactive systems to facilitate orientation, support usability and create consistency.
7. Research historic and current design precedents to contextualize your own work.
8. Be able to archive and document work that is printed, on screen or time based in a reflective manner for learning portfolio.
9. Combine your artistic creativity with technology related to the internet.
10. Demonstrate a comprehension of skills, methods, techniques and processes to realize interactive systems, particularly systems for dealing with unpredictable, variable, and ever-changing content.

Course Outline

Unit 1 Week 1–5: Semantics and Styles

The first segment of Core Interaction will focus on the environment and semantics required for building interactive experiences. We use the web as a starting point for students to understand what a screen-based interactive experience is, and what the opportunities are there for designers to intervene.

In weeks 1–5 we will focus on:

- Connecting HTML and CSS together
- Setting up our development environment
- How file systems and web browsers work together
- Semantic HTML and accessible websites
- Color and typography
- Responsive design and media queries (as it applies to type)
- Debugging

Unit 2 Week 5–10: Structures and Patterns

In our second segment, we'll investigate how designing for the digital canvas differs from other media. We will aim to understand the inherent complexities and how to use them to create compelling digital experiences.

In weeks 5–8 we will focus on:

- Using CSS display and position properties to structure the webpage
- Creating layouts using CSS positions, grid and flexbox
- Writing media queries for responsive styles
- Creating shared styles, elements and layouts for a multi-page website project
- Writing transitions for CSS properties
- Knowledge of common breakpoints

Unit 3 Week 10–15: Experiences and Tools

As we begin to develop systematic thinking through HTML and CSS practice, JavaScript will be introduced in our final segment for ideas of programming and automation. We will use web-based JavaScript to write functions and tools for ourselves and other audiences to use and play with.

In weeks 5-8 we will focus on:

- Writing in document JavaScript or connecting a script file
- Writing JavaScript variables and different types of data
- Writing JavaScript functions
- Accessing and manipulating DOM elements
- Arrays and accessing specific values
- Loop and event listener
- Objects and keys
- Using classList() to create interactive states
- Creating event listeners to basic mouse and window events

Assessment Criteria

25%	Attendance & Peer Critique
25%	Weekly entries and participation
25%	Midterm edit and written summary
25%	Final collection

Attendance, Grading and Work Submission Standards, Program Policies, Making Resources, and University Policies

All CD classes adhere to the same program and university policies:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1u358io8doX_SVVMGqIM_oH5V0OlcneYu4Ww-uE55QM/edit?usp=sharing

Projects

Unit 1 Week 1–5: Semantics and Styles

- Journal a walk or field trip (1a)
 - o Walk around somewhere and observe the environment around you. Bring along a journal or notetaking app. You could document people, plants, places you see along the way, for example. Turn this walk into a webpage by writing HTML. You should use a variety of tags to express your ideas.
- Document an interview you conducted with someone (1b)
 - o Conduct an interview with someone about a subject of your choosing. Record this interview and turn it into a webpage by writing HTML. You should use a variety of tags to express your ideas.
- Create a recipe (2)
 - o A recipe is a set of instructions to achieve a standardized result. A recipe is most typically thought of in a cooking context, but an algorithm is also a recipe. Create your own “recipe” in HTML. Then, have 2 other people make your recipe and document the results on the same webpage. You must use `<img>`, `<a>`, `<section>`, `<p>` at least once.

Unit 2 Week 5-10: Structures and Patterns

- Go to a museum and recreate a painting with CSS (3a)
 - o Find a museum that would allow you to open your laptop while observing an artwork. (Note - if this is truly not possible, go to a museum and take a photo of an artwork for later). Re-draw this painting on a webpage using CSS.
- Visual-only webpage (3b)
 - o Create a webpage that exists only for visual contemplation. It cannot have any usable functions nor serve a utilitarian purpose
- Re-create a website grid that you like (4)
 - o This is the opposite of the exercise with CSS painting. Find a website’s grid that you like and re-create it 1:1 using CSS grid and flexbox. You do not need to re-create the content, but you do need to re-create the website’s skeleton (show an example of what this means). You are not allowed to use manual positioning. The following CSS properties are not allowed: position, top, bottom, left, right.
- Collective entry for a web zine (5)
 - o A zine is a small, self-published booklet or magazine. It is usually made by one person or a tiny group. Your class will be creating its own web zine. As a class, create ideas for a collection centered around one theme. Then, use HTML and CSS to create your own “page” for the zine. Then, link all of your pages together to create a website.

Unit 3 Week 10-15: Experiences and Tools

- Make a clock with js (6)
 - o We provide the clock framework using `setInterval`. They have the chance to make it do something different depending on time of day using style, if/else, etc.
- Make an instrument with tiles or a keyboard (7a)

- Using events and interactions, create your own instrument. You can either make this instrument using clicks on screen, or with keyboard events.
- Made a keyboard for something other than typing; move mouse or keys to interact (7b)
- Build a website that can serve as a tool you could use daily (8)
 - Now that you know HTML, CSS, and JS, you have all the capabilities to create a web application. Using this knowledge, create a tool that you could use daily that lives on a webpage.

Communication Design Electronic Devices and AI Policy

([From our shared CD policies](#))

As a Communication Design student, you need to learn the opportunities and limitations in technology, particularly when it comes to emerging tools and interfaces. This can make it difficult to discern when these tools impede our learning.

Please observe the following guidelines and rules regarding devices:

1. **Using cell phones or laptops during class for any reason other than coursework is prohibited Parsons-wide.** Communicating with people outside of class is a distraction for your classmates. Use digital tools to limit others' access to your attention during class. The following tools are great for protecting your time:
 1. [The 'Focus' feature](#) on mac phones and laptops
 2. [The 'Fogos' app](#) (free, also can be paired with NFC tags)
 3. [The Freedom app](#), which allows for more customization
2. **You may not record faculty or other students without their permission, or without an accommodation from the disability office.**

And these guidelines regarding AI:

1. **You may not use AI to give feedback to other students or to write personal or project statements.** These are personal communications, and generic responses are not appropriate.
2. **You may not use AI to create content or design documents except in situations where:**
 1. that exploration is part of the assignment or
 2. that exploration is articulated within your concept for the project

Materials and Supplies

Laptop

Phone or recording device (for interviews and documentation)

Software: VS Code, Git/GitHub, Figma (free account)

Week	Date	Topic or activity	Assignment
1	Sep 1	Welcome and icebreakers; What is the internet, who is it for; semantic structure; linear/non-linear reading experiences	Intro Project 1 — choose 1a (Journal a walk) or 1b (Interview);
2	Sep 8	Typographic patterns on the web; typographic hierarchy and navigation; Figma: setup, organization, type styles	Continue Project 1; small-group critique and group exercise: non-linear reading
3	Sep 15	Responsive design (typography focus); accessibility (typography focus)	Project 1 due, critique; intro Project 2 (Recipe)
4	Sep 22	Experimental web typography	Continue Project 2; small-group critique and group exercise: web typography
5	Sep 29	Unit 1 wrap-up; project critique	Project 2 due, critique; intro Unit 2 and Project 3 - choose 3a (Museum painting) or 3b (Visual-only webpage)
6	Oct 6	What is an interface? Parts of an interface (button/menu/inputs)	Continue Project 3; small-group critique and group exercise: button
7	Oct 13	Behavioral states in design; affordances and microinteractions; usability and accessibility	Project 3 due, critique; intro Project 4 (Recreate a website grid)
8	Oct 20	Overview of generative AI tools and prompt generation	Continue Project 4; small-group critique and group exercise: memory file
9	Oct 27	Figma: reusable and dynamic elements - symbols, components, layout properties, variables and conditions	Project 4 due, critique; intro Project 5 (Collective web zine)
10	Nov 3	Recap of creating your presentation deck	Project 5 due, critique; intro Unit 3
11	Nov 10	User research; personas/archetypes; user journeys and flows	Small-group critique and group exercise: user journey
12	Nov 17	Figma: prototyping, styles, plugins	Intro Project 6 (Clock with JS); small-group critique and group exercise: Figma prototype

Week	Date	Topic or activity	Assignment
13	Nov 24	User testing methods; Figma variables, Dev Mode (and its limitations)	Project 6 due, critique; intro Project 7 - choose 7a (Instrument) or 7b (Alternate keyboard)
14	Dec 1	Studio work session	Project 7 due, critique; intro Project 8 (Daily tool website)
15	Dec 8	Final project critique (10 min/student)	Project 8 due